wanted to get the president on his side. “There is a possibility, only a possibility,” continued Rusk, “that Mr. Khrushchev might realize that he’s got to back down on this.”[6]

The reference to Tuchman’s book failed to sway Kennedy. He was as committed to the idea of an unannounced strike as he had been the previous day, when McCone visited him in the White House. He was also less than enthusiastic about approaching Khrushchev, whom he expected to respond to the warning with a warning of his own: “[I]f you take them out, we are going to take Berlin” or “We are going to do something else.” Kennedy believed that striking first and negotiating second was a better alternative. But he could not stop thinking about Berlin and the impact that Khrushchev’s actions there would have on America’s European allies. “If he grabs Berlin,” remarked Kennedy, “everybody would feel we lost Berlin, because of these missiles, which I say, do not bother them.” “What do we do when he moves into Berlin?” asked Robert Kennedy. Bundy, who had had more than enough trouble with Berlin in the previous few months, suggested with a chuckle that it would be good to trade it off “and not have it our fault.”

That was clearly an impossibility. “We have US troops there. What do they do?” remarked McNamara. “They fight,” responded General Taylor. “And they get overrun,” joined in John Kennedy. “It’s then general war,” said one of the participants, continuing that line of thinking. “You mean nuclear exchange?” inquired Kennedy. Rusk, for once, was not advocating diplomacy. “You would have to start at least with tactical nuclear weapons,” he told the president. “The question really is to what [degree] action we take lessens the chances of a nuclear exchange, which obviously is the final failure. And at the same time, maintain some degree of solidarity with our allies,” said Kennedy, drawing a line under that part of the discussion.[7]

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THE SITUATION LOOKED GRIM WHEN JOHN KENNEDY LEFT his advisers for lunch and returned to his prearranged schedule. It happened to include a meeting that might dramatically alter the course of the rapidly expanding